

Louis Sullivan

Known as the Father of American Modernism, Louis Sullivan (1856–1924), with his partner Dankmar Adler (1844–1900), embraced developing technologies to form a new language for tall buildings. In 1889, they designed the ten-storey Chicago Auditorium Building. As Chicago sits on a swamp, Adler devised a raft of timbers, steel and iron I-beams to ‘float’ the building on the marsh. In 1894 they developed a caisson construction for the Chicago Stock Exchange, which allowed water to be pumped out from the foundations. It became a model for tall buildings across the US. Decoration was not entirely omitted: in their 10-storey Wainwright Building in St Louis (1891), the steel-frame construction terminates in a frieze and projecting cornice, and their 16-storey Guaranty (now Prudential) Building in Buffalo (1896, opposite) is encased in terracotta. But while traces of neoclassicism, Romanesque revival, Romanticism and art nouveau show in his work, Sullivan was original. His Carson Pirie Scott department store in Chicago (1899–1904) also emphasizes verticality, but with large, horizontal windows.

